

1. INT. SCHOOL COUNSELOR'S OFFICE- AFTERNOON

WIDE SHOT- We look at a typical therapist's office, two comfortable beige recliners sit on either end of a large wooden desk.

The FIRST TEENAGER slouches in his plush recliner, blood from his lip drips right onto the designer logo on his T-shirt, He doesn't wipe it off. Rather, he fidgets trying his best to appear indifferent.

The SECOND TEENAGER stares at the FIRST TEENAGER with a smirk on his face, clearly with the intent to make him uncomfortable. Tears trickle from one eye, he doesn't blink.

COUNSELOR

You both ended up here for the same reason, maybe that reason isn't just about-

(points to SECOND TEENAGER)

Your bloody fist, and-

(points to FIRST TEENAGER)

Your swollen cheek.

SECOND TEENAGER

Oh. There's no mystery here, some people just need to be reminded about their place in the world.

FIRST TEENAGER

My place? You think you get to decide that for me? All you've got is a last name and a trust fund Lucas.

LUCAS

Do you really think that-

The COUNSELOR cuts him off midway, she sets down an ambiguous looking file on her desk.

COUNSELOR

(sighs)

This conversation has happened too many times. I want to know why this pattern keeps repeating.

The CAMERA FOLLOWS the trunk of the car-

The low roar of a V8 rumbles from outside. The COUNSELOR parts the curtains, peering through the glass. A shaft of sunlight strikes LUCAS, his loud, flashy clothes glowing under the glare. The faint sound of argument arises from the car.

COUNSELOR

Atleast try to keep it together infront of your parents, Noah.

NOAH, sits up straight, he wipes the blood of his mouth and hands, he straightens his collar and looks apprehensively at the door.

The MOTHER enters first, she looks directly at NOAH and scoffs. The FATHER enters a few seconds later.

FATHER

(on the phone)

I've reviewed the merger proposal,
but we'll need legal's input before
moving forward—

(apologetic)

But, listen I have to cut this short,
we'll talk tonight.

The parents take a seat inbetween the two boys.

MOTHER

(cold, dismissive)

Really, Noah? Again? Your brother is
on track to be valedictorian, and
you... you can't seem to stay out of
trouble. Why is it so hard for you
not to be a problem?

NOAH

(defensive)

It wasn't my fault. He hit me first.
All I did was stand up for myself,
isn't that what you told me to do.

MOTHER

(flat, uninterested)

Don't twist my words, Noah. You
always have an excuse. If you put
half as much effort into school as
you do into playing the victim, maybe
we wouldn't be sitting here.

LUCAS

(chuckles)

See, even Mom knows—

COUNSELOR

(firm)

Not now, Lucas.

The FATHER tunes out the rising voices in the room: the counselor's measured reprimand, the mother's cutting retorts, even Lucas's stifled snicker. None of it registers. Instead, his gaze lingers on Noah. He studies the split lip, the bruises blooming along his jaw and collarbone, the faint tremor in his hands as he tries to keep them steady on his knees.

CUT TO:

3. EXT. CITY PARK- 10 YEARS AGO- DAY

WIDE SHOT- A couple walks side by side, fingers entwined, watching as their little boy waddles in front of them.

MOTHER

He's getting faster every day. Pretty soon, we won't be able to keep up.

FATHER

(chuckles, then exhales)
Yeah... and that's what's been on my mind.

MOTHER

(looks at him)
What is it?

FATHER

I got a call this morning. An investor—he's a huge name in this space—he wants to dump a ridiculous amount of money into the company. Enough to double our size overnight.

MOTHER

That's... good, isn't it?

FATHER

(pauses, watching their son)
It should be. Everyone at the office is treating it like a miracle. But all I can think is... if I say yes, I'm signing away the little time I still get with you two. More hours, more flights, more late nights.

MOTHER

(softly)
You're scared of missing this.

FATHER

(points toward their son)
Exactly. Look at him—wobbling along, holding the world in his tiny hands. I don't want to blink and suddenly he's taller than me, and I'm just some stranger who built a company instead of a life.

MOTHER

Look, if you need to chase this opportunity, do it. I'll hold down the fort—meals, bedtime, all the chaos. I can handle it.

4. INT. SCHOOL COUNSELOR'S OFFICE- PRESENT- AFTERNOON

The COUNSELOR motions for LUCAS and NOAH to exit the room. LUCAS stands up, looks directly at NOAH, and then exits, NOAH follows behind shortly, averting his gaze from his Dad.

COUNSELOR

Sir? Sir? I really need you to pay attention, this isn't something you can tune out of.

The FATHER looks up at the COUNSELOR

COUNSELOR

I could sit here and read from this folder, list every fight, every failing grade, every suspension. But I don't think that would tell you anything you don't already know. You've seen the bruises. You've heard the calls from the school.
(beat, weary yet steady)
What I want you to understand is this: your son is caught in a pattern that isn't going to fix itself. I know this is a difficult time for you. It's your first time being a parent, but you're still treating him like a child. Don't wait until your son is too far gone before you realize you could've reached him. The bruises will fade, but the distance between you? That only grows if you keep pretending he'll just grow out of this on his own.
(quiet sadness in her voice)
I know what it's like to lose something you thought would last, he won't be an innocent kid again, you have to come to terms with that.

The FATHER stares at the COUNSELOR, lost for words, the room is silent, except for the faint vibration of his phone.

FATHER

(rough)
... I don't even know him anymore. I don't know what his hobbies are, who his friends are, what he wants- what he dreams about... I have no idea. I don't know where to begin.

The FATHER picks up his phone, and he powers it off.

What if it's too late. What if he's
already written me off.

COUNSELOR

(quiet, firm)

Then you prove him wrong. Every day.
Until he believes otherwise.

5. INT. BEDROOM- NIGHT

The room is quiet, lit only by the desk lamp. The CAMERA
TRACKS- The FATHER as he paces by the window, phone pressed to
his ear.

FATHER

on the phone)...I've already spoken
with legal. Forget the merger-I'm
selling the whole company.

He listens, a shaky breath slipping out as the voice on the
other end protests.

No... listen to me. I've made my
decision. This isn't about business
anymore. It's final.

He cuts the call and lowers into his chair, a small smile
breaks out onto his face. For the first time he looks
unburdened.

FADE OUT